Inspection of East Riding of Yorkshire local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 8 to 12 June 2026

Lead inspector: Jenny-Ellen Scotland, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	**Grade**
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Good

Children and care leavers in East Riding of Yorkshire benefit from services that are increasingly effective and underpinned by a strong relational practice model. Family networks are a golden thread throughout children's experiences, influencing practice and supporting positive change from family help to leaving care. Most children receive timely and appropriate support that responds to their needs, risks and circumstances. Children and most care leavers benefit from stable relationships with committed practitioners who know them well.

There is some variability in the quality and responsiveness of services for a small number of children, including some care leavers, children who present as homeless and children living in private fostering arrangements. High caseloads in some services affect service delivery.

Since the previous inspection, stronger management oversight, improved partnership working and a sustained focus on relational practice mean that most children, families and care leavers receive support that is responsive to their needs and builds on the strengths within their family networks. Leaders have a clear understanding of areas requiring further development and have ambitions to continue improving children's experiences to help them achieve positive futures.

What needs to improve?[1]

- The response to children aged 16 to 17 years who are presenting as homeless and for those living in private fostering arrangements. (outcome 2, national framework)
- The assessment of need for care leavers who may be vulnerable, particularly for those in custody or living out of area. (outcome 4, national framework)
- Caseloads for practitioners in the strengthening and supporting families teams and the care leaving service. (outcome 1, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and families benefit from a broad range of early help services. The redesigned early help service into a family help service, underpinned by a well-established relational family network model, is helping children and families to receive the right help at the right time. One family hub is operational, with clear plans to expand the hub offer across East Riding, improving access for children and families in communities across the region and supporting the implementation of the Families First Partnership (FFP) reforms.

2. The interface between family help and statutory social work is well managed, so that children move proportionately between services as their needs change.

3. Referrals to the Safeguarding and Partnership Hub (SAPH) are timely and appropriate. The co-location of family help and safeguarding teams within a single front door supports effective decision-making and ensures that children and families receive the most appropriate response to their needs. Partner agencies demonstrate a clear understanding of the respective referral pathways, while practitioners in the SAPH provide oversight by reviewing referrals and ensuring that families are directed to the most suitable services.

4. Screening of contacts and referrals about concerns for children is thorough and supported by a range of tools, including domestic abuse and neglect toolkits. Practitioners consistently draw on family history, multi-agency information and information from parents and the wider family network, resulting in balanced and accurate threshold decisions. Safety planning is routinely considered, with plans appropriately addressing identified risks and promoting children's immediate safety and wellbeing.

[1] The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the Children's Social Care: National Framework. This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

5. SAPH managers provide effective oversight at decision-making points, supporting analysis, maintaining timeliness and ensuring effective decisions.

6. When children need statutory help or protection, they are transferred promptly to the local children's assessment team. Social workers respond effectively to escalating risk, convening well-attended multi-agency child protection strategy discussions. Child protection enquiries are characterised by clear analysis and meaningful engagement with children and families, supporting well-reasoned decision-making. Safety plans are regularly reviewed throughout the process to ensure that they remain responsive to identified risks for children.

7. Children who require support or who are at risk of harm benefit from thorough and timely assessments that clearly identify risks, needs and strengths for children and within their family networks. Children's views, wishes and feelings are actively sought and meaningfully considered. The views of parents, including non-resident parents and extended family members, inform assessments, providing a clear understanding of children's circumstances and the support required. Following assessment, practitioners enable children and families to transition to the most appropriate services, whether this is universal provision, family help or, when statutory support is required, the strengthening and supporting families teams.

8. Children's plans are appropriately child focused and are co-produced with parents, partner agencies and, when appropriate, children. Plans are reviewed regularly through well-attended core groups and child in need meetings, ensuring that progress is monitored and support remains responsive to changing needs or risk. Contingency planning is consistently considered through family network meetings and is clearly reflected in children's plans.

9. Social workers within the assessment teams and strengthening and supporting families teams spend time getting to know children and understanding their needs. Visits and direct work are purposeful, enabling children and their families to build stable and positive relationships with their social workers. The relational practice model is embedded, with a strong focus on building trusting relationships that support meaningful engagement and positive change for most children and their families.

10. Disabled children are supported well, with an effective response to their needs and safeguarding concerns through thorough assessment, effective planning and strong multi-agency support. Practitioners demonstrate a sensitive understanding of children's circumstances, holistically exploring their needs, alongside the support provided by carers and the wider professional network.

11. Pre-proceedings processes, as part of the Public Law Outline, are appropriate, well-structured and monitored closely, with effective tracking that prevents drift. Support from the intensive family support service is enabling many families to make sustainable changes and to be successfully diverted from legal

proceedings. When there is no meaningful change or there are immediate safeguarding concerns, care proceedings are issued promptly.

12. Family networks are genuinely valued and considered at every juncture of the child's journey. Network meetings are used effectively to identify strengths and support within wider family networks and to develop contingency plans when children cannot be safely cared for by their parents.

13. There is a well-coordinated, multi-agency response to children who are experiencing extra-familial harm and/or who go missing from home or care. Multi-agency meetings are held regularly and support effective information-sharing, alongside proactive disruption and diversion activity to reduce risk. Children benefit from strong support from the making a change team, working alongside their allocated practitioners. Return home interviews, known as 'missing chats', are completed promptly and provide valuable insight into children's experiences and circumstances.

14. Children who are experiencing neglect and/or domestic abuse receive a prompt and effective response. Practice in relation to domestic abuse is informed by practitioners who recognise indicators of harm and use appropriate tools to explore impact, parental conflict and family dynamics. Social workers are skilled at engaging those who pose a risk of harm through domestic abuse. They remain child focused and ensure that victims of abuse are appropriately supported. While children experiencing neglect receive an appropriate response, practice is less well developed, and the neglect toolkit is not used consistently.

15. Practice for children living in private fostering arrangements is underdeveloped. There is currently limited awareness-raising activity, meaning such arrangements may remain unidentified and children may not receive the safeguarding oversight or support they require. For the small number of children who have been identified, there has been a delay in their identification, although they are now supported through effective assessment and planning.

16. Children aged 16 or 17 who are at risk of, or experiencing, homelessness receive a variable response. For some children, they are successfully supported to return home, but for others, responses are too slow and do not ensure that they fully understand their rights, options or how to access advocacy. Leaders recognise these shortfalls and acknowledge that further work is required to strengthen practice, including improving the coordination and timeliness of joint homelessness assessments with housing services.

17. For some children identified as young carers there are delays in assessment of their needs, impacting on their timely access to a service. Once assessments are complete, children benefit from a range of resources such as activities, one-to-one support and support groups. These provide opportunities for children to take a break from caring responsibilities and enable them to enjoy being children. Recent action has strengthened oversight, resulting in fewer children waiting for assessment.

18. Children and families are supported out of hours by the children's emergency duty team, where skilled and experienced practitioners respond swiftly and effectively to safeguard children and respond to a wide range of presenting needs and risks. Out-of-hours contacts for care leavers are managed through the adult services out-of-hours service, which ensures that relevant information is shared with the young person's personal adviser for follow up.

19. The local authority designated officer service responds promptly to referrals of concerns about adults working with children, ensuring that individual cases progress appropriately and supporting partners and employers to address risk.

20. Appropriate management oversight is evident throughout children's journeys and at key decision-making points. Records reflect thoughtful management discussions and well-reasoned decisions that are recorded in a way that children can understand, should they read their records in the future.

21. Leaders have responded effectively to a significant increase in children being electively home educated, supporting families and maintaining a strong focus on safeguarding. Clear systems help ensure the safety and wellbeing of children who are electively home educated.

22. For children who are not in full-time education, effective multi-agency support and partnership working are evident. Oversight is robust, with interventions tailored to individual needs and a clear focus on supporting children to return to full-time education when appropriate.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

23. Children in care are receiving a good service, and most children benefit from stable homes, positive and enduring relationships with their social workers and the support of committed carers. Since the previous inspection, children's participation has become meaningful and influential, ensuring that children's voices influence decisions about their lives as well as the development of services for children in care.

24. Most children enter care in a planned way when they cannot remain safely in their parents' care. Family group conferences and family network meetings are routinely used to support care planning and identify kinship options, allowing the early identification of potential family carers, enabling children to sustain important relationships.

25. Most children in care live in stable and nurturing homes that are local to their family homes and where they feel safe, happy and make good progress.

26. Brothers and sisters live together whenever possible, unless assessment identifies this is not in their best interests. Family time with parents, brothers and sisters and wider family members is purposeful, well planned and focused on maintaining positive relationships. This helps children to maintain and strengthen relationships and promotes their sense of identity.

27. Permanence planning starts early for most children, either before or shortly after they enter care. Permanence pathways are subject to appropriate senior leadership oversight, ensuring plans are progressed. For a small number of babies, early permanence has not been considered, creating delays in securing permanence.

28. Many children achieve permanence through kinship arrangements, supported by child-centred assessments and careful planning. Senior leaders maintain suitable oversight of these arrangements to ensure that they are in children's best interests.

29. Reunification with parents or wider family is consistently considered and reviewed throughout the child's journey. When it is assessed as safe for children to return to the care of their parents or wider family, decision-making is effective. Reunification is carefully planned and supported, with attention to practical and emotional needs.

30. Disabled children in care receive a sensitive and child-centred service from their social workers. Social workers use a range of communication methods and direct work to understand children's individual needs, wishes and feelings to inform care planning. Positive relationships are maintained with parents, recognising the importance of these relationships in supporting children's identity, continuity and lifelong connections.

31. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children receive sensitive, well-informed support from practitioners who understand their complex experiences and traumatic histories. While children live in homes that meet their assessed needs, for some, these do not reflect their cultural, religious or identity needs. Practitioners address this through culturally responsive support, including Eid celebrations and football activities, to promote inclusion and a sense of belonging. Translated key documents are not always provided when requested, limiting children's understanding of their plans.

32. Most children living in supported accommodation have the independence skills needed for their placement. This is strengthened by the local authority's own registered supported accommodation provision. Social workers and the virtual school work together to support children to access education, employment and training opportunities aligned to their future aspirations.

33. A small number of children live in unlawful, unregistered children's homes. Most children make progress. Some achieve multiple improvements based on the strategic intent to keep them in East Riding. Leaders and practitioners maintain regular oversight of these arrangements, with social workers visiting more frequently, while persistently seeking registered homes. There is evidence that some children will move to more suitable accommodation in the near future.

34. Children in care who go missing and/or who are at risk of exploitation benefit from a well-coordinated multi-agency response to assess risk and agree actions

to reduce and manage harm. Responses to missing-from-care episodes are prompt, with additional support from the making a change team, helping to reduce risks and improve safety for children. Oversight is maintained through regular multi-agency risk panels and meetings, ensuring that risks are understood, consistently monitored and managed effectively.

35. Children in care enjoy relationships with their social workers, who know them well and who are genuinely proud of their progress and achievements. They spend quality time with their social workers, enabling them to share worries and celebrate successes. Most children are helped to understand their care histories through sensitive, individualised direct work and life-story work tailored to their needs and circumstances.

36. For most children, care plans are well written, updated regularly and provide sufficient detail about children's needs and how these are to be met, which ensures that they receive care that meets their needs well.

37. Children in care reviews are held regularly and are well attended by those who are important to the children. Independent reviewing officers (IROs) write clear, thoughtful letters following reviews, helping children to understand their histories and the decisions made about their care. These provide valuable records for children to refer to over time.

38. Most children benefit from effective IRO oversight and strong scrutiny of their plans. However, changes in IRO allocation for some children have limited continuity and relationship-building. Virtual reviews can sometimes limit IROs' ability to know children well and understand their experiences.

39. Children's health needs are prioritised and well understood, with a majority having up-to-date health assessments and an increasing number receiving regular dental checks. They are supported to access universal health services and receive dedicated support from the looked-after child and mental health service when required.

40. Children are supported effectively by the virtual school to make good educational progress. Children in care are supported to attend and remain in school. Attendance rates are favourable, and the rate of permanent exclusion of children in care is low. Personal education plans are of a consistent high quality and support children's progress well. There was consistently positive feedback from partner agencies about the support of the virtual school.

41. Children in care are encouraged and supported to participate in a wide range of enrichment activities that give them the opportunity to learn new skills and promote enjoyment, confidence and personal development.

42. The processes and systems to recruit foster carers have been refreshed, with increased use of social media to attract a more diverse range of carers. The fostering service offers a strong package of support, with locality-based activities

improving accessibility and engagement. The fostering panel is well established, with a diverse and skilled core membership.

43. Plans for adoption are carefully considered for children who cannot return home or live with kinship carers. Strong links between the local authority and the regional adoption agency (One Adoption North and Humber) mean that children are matched effectively and assisted to settle into their adoptive homes. A multi-agency wellbeing panel provides specialist support to help prevent placement disruption. When children are matched to an adoptive parent or parents, careful transition planning helps children settle into their new families.

44. Children are increasingly involved in shaping service design through established forums, including the Children in Care Council, Care Leavers Forum and the Young Ambassadors programme. Their attendance at the Corporate Parenting Board is enabling them to have a more direct and positive impact on decision-making.

45. Children who spoke with inspectors consistently reported that they are happy with where they live and with their carers. They have trusted adults they can turn to if needed, reflecting the stability and strength of relationships across the service.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: good

46. Most care leavers benefit from supportive relationships with committed personal advisers (PAs) who know them well, advocate effectively and celebrate their achievements. PAs are allocated early, enabling trusting relationships to develop and providing a strong foundation for effective support as care leavers prepare for adulthood. High caseloads limit opportunities for PAs to visit more frequently than every 8 weeks and to respond more flexibly to care leavers' changing needs.

47. Care leavers are pleased to now have access to services and support through the new hub in Beverley, where PAs are based. The hub has been co-designed with care leavers, who are benefiting from the practical and emotional support available within a space dedicated to them. They are also helping to shape future services, including support groups. Plans to establish similar hubs in other locations will extend access to these valuable resources across the local authority, reducing the need for care leavers to travel significant distances to access support.

48. Most care leavers benefit from supportive relationships with their Pas, who know them well and advocate effectively for them, although high PA caseloads can at times limit contact. Practitioners are proud of the young people they work with, and they celebrate their achievements.

49. During this inspection, a small number of care leavers under the age of 21 were identified as having had their cases prematurely closed. Leaders were not aware

of these cases and took immediate action to reopen them to ensure that support is provided.

50. Care leavers can choose whether to continue receiving support from the leaving care service after the age of 21, and those who remain engaged receive effective support. Keeping-in-touch arrangements for care leavers who have opted out are inconsistent in a small number of cases. While most young people receive regular reminders of their entitlement to support, this is not consistently evident. There were examples where contact was not evidenced within expected timescales, resulting in missed opportunities to identify changes in circumstances and provide support that is responsive to care leavers' needs.

51. Care leavers play an active and influential role in shaping and developing services, representing a significant improvement since the last inspection. Young ambassadors and representatives from the Care Leavers Forum contribute to the development of important documents, including the pledge, local offer and pathway plans. They participate in decision-making forums across the local authority and report that senior leaders listen and act on their views. Care leavers speak positively about the difference they make and take genuine pride in their contribution to improving services for their peers.

52. Most care leavers receive effective support to promote their physical and emotional wellbeing. They are linked promptly to appropriate health services, and their health needs are routinely reviewed. Care leavers are supported to access and understand their health histories with the NHS app, helping them to take greater ownership of their health as they move into adulthood. When care leavers require support with their emotional wellbeing, they are helped to access universal community mental health services. Strong links between the leaving care service and the looked-after child and mental health service also provide care leavers with timely access to specialist mental health support when needed.

53. Care leavers are aware of their entitlements within the local offer. PAs are proactive in ensuring that young people understand what support is available and how to access it. The local offer has been co-produced with care-experienced young people, ensuring that it reflects their views and priorities. The offer has been strengthened through increases to the leaving care grant and bursaries, alongside the introduction of a rental guarantor scheme. Free Wi-Fi was introduced on a time-limited basis, and senior leaders recognise the positive benefits of this as they review additional discretionary support.

54. Most care leavers are involved in the development of their pathway plans. PAs adapt discussions to care leavers' abilities and preferences, and plans are generally written with sensitivity. The quality of plans is variable. Stronger plans are detailed, informed by the young person and relevant agencies, and contain clear actions to support progress towards adulthood. Some plans are not updated when significant changes occur, meaning they do not always reflect care leavers' changing circumstances.

55. For a small number of care leavers, PAs do not consistently demonstrate sufficient professional curiosity when potential indicators of vulnerability emerge. This is particularly evident when care leavers are placed out of area. While no care leavers were identified as being at risk, this reduces PAs' awareness of and insight into young people's changing circumstances.

56. Care leavers are well supported to access education, employment and training opportunities. PAs and the virtual school are proactive and tenacious in helping young people identify and pursue opportunities that reflect their interests, aspirations and abilities. This includes access to apprenticeships within the local authority and through established partnerships with local businesses. As a result, most care leavers are engaged in education, employment or training or have clear plans in place to support them into suitable opportunities.

57. Most care leavers live in accommodation that is suitable to their needs and stage of independence. The support available helps young people to develop their independence skills progressively and with confidence. Accommodation is planned thoughtfully, with consideration given to location and the importance of maintaining relationships with significant people in young people's lives.

58. Care leavers are supported to obtain the key documents they need for adult life, helping them to prepare for greater independence.

59. Care leavers in custody receive a variable quality of service. Although PAs maintain regular contact through visits, pathway plans do not consistently assess financial needs or provide sufficiently detailed planning for the support young people require while in custody and upon their release.

60. Former unaccompanied asylum-seeking care leavers are generally well supported. Most benefit from suitable accommodation, timely legal advice regarding their immigration status and support to access education and develop independence. Inspectors found positive evidence of pathway planning and partnership working. In a small number of cases, inspectors identified gaps in contact, resulting in practical and emotional needs that are not always identified or responded to promptly.

61. Care leavers who are parents receive kind, sensitive and supportive help to develop their parenting skills. PAs are mindful of the potential stigma experienced by care leavers who become parents, particularly linked to their care histories, and provide thoughtful, non-judgmental support to help them build confidence and to strengthen their social and family networks.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

62. East Riding of Yorkshire benefits from stable, visible and ambitious leadership. Political and corporate leaders, including the chief executive, provide strong support for children and care leavers, ensuring that they remain central to the

council's priorities. The director of children's services and senior leadership team provide confident, strategic leadership and maintain a clear focus on improving the lives of children, families and care leavers. Senior leaders are resilient and values driven, supported by a committed workforce and a well-embedded relational practice model that is consistently evident in practice with children and families.

63. Since the last inspection, leaders have made positive progress in the areas identified for improvement. Political leaders are highly supportive of the children's agenda. Despite significant financial pressures, leaders continue to prioritise investment in services to improve the lives of children, families and care leavers.

64. Leaders have a strong understanding of the service and its performance. Their self-assessment is comprehensive and self-critical and, in most areas, aligns with the findings of this inspection, although there are some areas of service that require further attention, such as performance in relation to children living in private fostering arrangements.

65. Leaders have successfully redesigned early help into a family help service and embedded family hubs within the local authority's strategic approach, aligning their development with the FFP reforms. A relational practice model is embedded throughout the service, strengthening the use of family networks, which are now a golden thread running through children's experiences and influencing practice from family help through to leaving care. The making a change team and intensive family support service are delivering positive change for children through effective support and intervention. Children, families and care leavers are now meaningfully involved in shaping services and influencing their development.

66. Leaders have improved the quality and impact of partnership working with key strategic partners. This is evident in the design and implementation of the family hub programme, effective delivery of the SAPH, the looked-after children child and mental health service and the successful securing of funding for an emotional wellbeing support programme for care leavers.

67. Appropriate management oversight is evident across the stages of children's journeys, providing clear direction and accountability for key decisions. Family networks are a golden thread woven throughout children's experiences of services, shaping practice and improving children's experiences from early help through to leaving care.

68. Leaders are committed to their corporate parenting responsibilities and demonstrate a collective responsibility for children in care and care leavers. There is a strong sense that 'these are our children' reflected in the value placed on their voices and the meaningful influence they now have on service development and decision-making.

69. Leaders have a strong understanding of their sufficiency challenges and are undertaking purposeful action to address them. This includes refreshing fostering recruitment and expanding local provision through registered in-house children's homes and supported accommodation. Keeping children safely within their families is central to East Riding's sufficiency strategy, with early evidence that this approach is making a difference to children. While most children in care live in fostering households, of which many are in-house carers, a small and decreasing number of children continue to live in unlawful unregistered children's homes. Ensuring that there is sufficient registered provision to meet the needs of children in care is an area that remains a focus for leaders.

70. Leaders benefit from a well-developed performance framework that provides clear oversight of service performance and emerging trends. However, leaders have not used available performance information to identify and monitor allocation of services to care leavers aged 18 to 21. Reflective quality assurance activity, including case reviews and feedback from children and families, supports practice improvement and improves children's experiences.

71. Leaders are committed to continuous improvement and to developing a strong learning culture. Practitioners have ready access to training that is appropriate and relevant to their areas of practice, including training aligned with the local authority's chosen practice model.

72. A comprehensive workforce development strategy, including 'grow our own' initiatives, has increased the number of permanent social workers. Recruitment remains challenging, and caseloads are too high in some teams, particularly within the care leaving service. Leaders are taking steps to address these issues, and social workers in the strengthening and supporting families teams report positive improvements. Nevertheless, high caseloads in the care leaver service continue to affect the quality and responsiveness of some practice and limit workers' capacity for training, development and wellbeing.

73. Social workers are very positive about working for East Riding of Yorkshire. Practitioners feel respected and valued by leaders and appreciate the supportive, caring and inclusive environment across the authority.

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